

Ancistrus dolichopterus

Bushymouth catfish

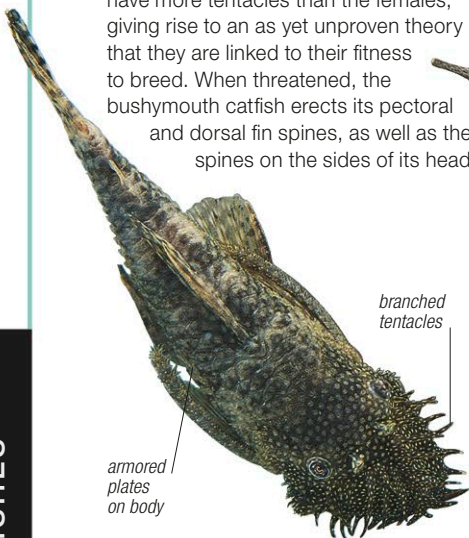


Length Up to 5 in (13 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location N. South America



The bushymouth catfish and its close relatives get their name from the distinctive fleshy tentacles on the upperside of their snouts. The males have more tentacles than the females, giving rise to an as yet unproven theory that they are linked to their fitness to breed. When threatened, the bushymouth catfish erects its pectoral and dorsal fin spines, as well as the spines on the sides of its head.



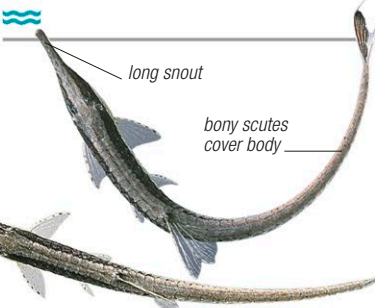
Farlowella acus

Whiptail catfish



Length Up to 6 in (15 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location N.W. South America



Although they are almost all bottom dwellers, catfishes exhibit a remarkable diversity of body form. The whiptail catfish is unusually long and slender, with a pointed snout, and is camouflaged to resemble a piece of sunken wood. It lives in slow-flowing rivers, and feeds mainly on river-bed algae after dark. During the day, it relies on its cryptic color and shape to protect it from attack. Females lay their eggs on the river bed, and the males guard them until they hatch.

Clarias batrachus

Philippine catfish



Length Up to 16 in (40 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location S. and S.E. Asia



This long-bodied catfish has the ability to crawl overland, using its pectoral fins to gain purchase. While on land, it breathes through its specially modified gills, which have strengthened filaments, preventing them from collapsing when exposed to air. The Philippine catfish lives in slow-moving water, walking overland to reach suitable habitats. It is a popular aquarium species; the piebald variety shown here is one of several kinds that have been bred.

Vandellia cirrhosa

Candiru



Length Up to 1 in (2.5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



A tiny catfish with a slender, almost transparent body, the candiru has an unusual way of life. Instead of feeding in open water, it swims into the gill cavities of larger fishes—particularly larger catfishes and characins—using the large, hooked spines of its own gill cover to lodge itself in the gill tissue of its host. It then bites off pieces of gill with its fine, comblike teeth, and feeds on the released blood. Candirus are notorious for swimming up the urethras of mammals, even humans, urinating in rivers. It is thought that, in these instances, the candiru mistakes the flow of urine for the stream of water expelled from the gills of larger fishes.

Synodontis contractus

Upside-down catfish

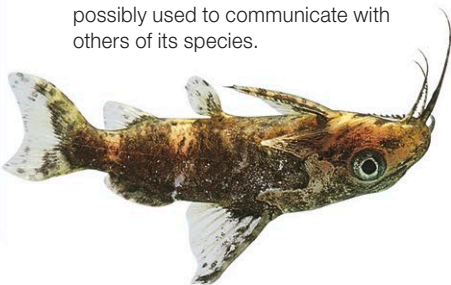


Length 3¼ in (9.5 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location C. Africa



This African catfish swims upside-down near the surface of rivers and streams, particularly when taking food from the surface or feeding from the undersides of broad leaves and rocks. Its diet includes plant material, aquatic invertebrates, and insect larvae. The upside-down catfish is entirely brown or brown-violet, with a series of small spots scattered across its body. Most fishes are dark above and light beneath—a pattern called countershading that serves as a means of camouflage. In this fish, the arrangement is often reversed, with the underside being darker than the back. Also known as the bug-eye squeaker, it makes sounds, which are possibly used to communicate with others of its species.



Bagre marinus

Gafftopsail sea catfish



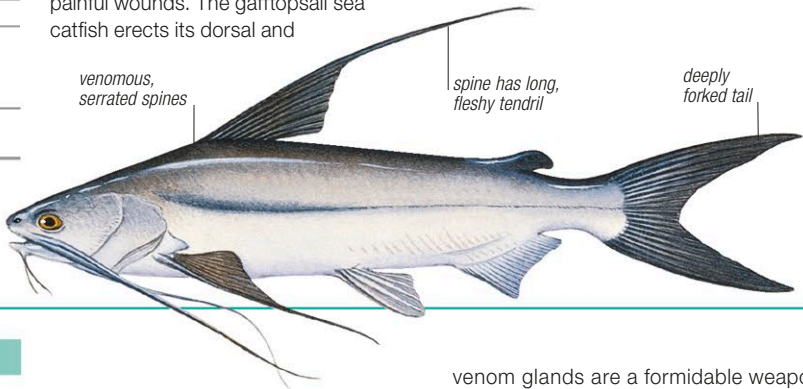
Length Up to 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight Up to 8¼ lb (4 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location W. Central Atlantic, Gulf of Mexico, Caribbean



Commercially exploited as a food source, this Atlantic catfish is mainly marine, but sometimes swims into estuaries that have relatively high

salinity levels. Its head has a hard, bony shield, but its most conspicuous features are the very long, flattened barbels attached to the sides of its mouth, and the long spines that arch outward from its dorsal and pectoral fins. These serrated spines are also venomous and can inflict painful wounds. The gafftopsail sea catfish erects its dorsal and



pectoral spines when threatened. This fish is a bottom-feeder, eating crustaceans and other fishes. During the breeding season (between May and August), the male gafftopsail sea catfish fertilizes the female's eggs and broods them in his mouth until they hatch.

Ameiurus nebulosus

Brown bullhead



Length Up to 20½ in (52 cm)
Weight 5½–7¼ lb (2.5–3.5 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location E. North America



This common catfish belongs to a large family of freshwater fishes found in North America. Like other members of the family, it is valued as a food fish.

It has a scaleless body, and a large mouth surrounded by 4 pairs of fleshy barbels, which it uses to find food. Its jagged, dagger-like pectoral spines with attached



venom glands are a formidable weapon against predators. Both parents guard the eggs in the nest, fanning to increase the air flow around them, and herd the young in tight schools until they reach a length of about 2 in (5 cm).